

METHODS OF TEA PRODUCTION

When you make a cup of tea you will notice that some leaves resemble little grains of soil, while others look like they were just plucked from the tea plant. This difference is largely determined by the method of production used on the leaf. There are two methods for producing tea in a factory: the CTC (crush, tear, curl) method and the orthodox method.

CTC METHOD

Invented in the 1930s, this method involves the use of industrial machinery to process tea leaves. Large, thick leaves of a lower grade are blade-sliced, crushed, and bruised (to speed up oxidation), then machine-rolled into tiny grains of equal size before they undergo oxidation. This method is used exclusively in the production of black tea, and mostly for commodity tea (grown in industrial gardens for commercial uses). The CTC method is particularly prevalent in Sri Lanka, Kenya, and parts of India, but not in China.

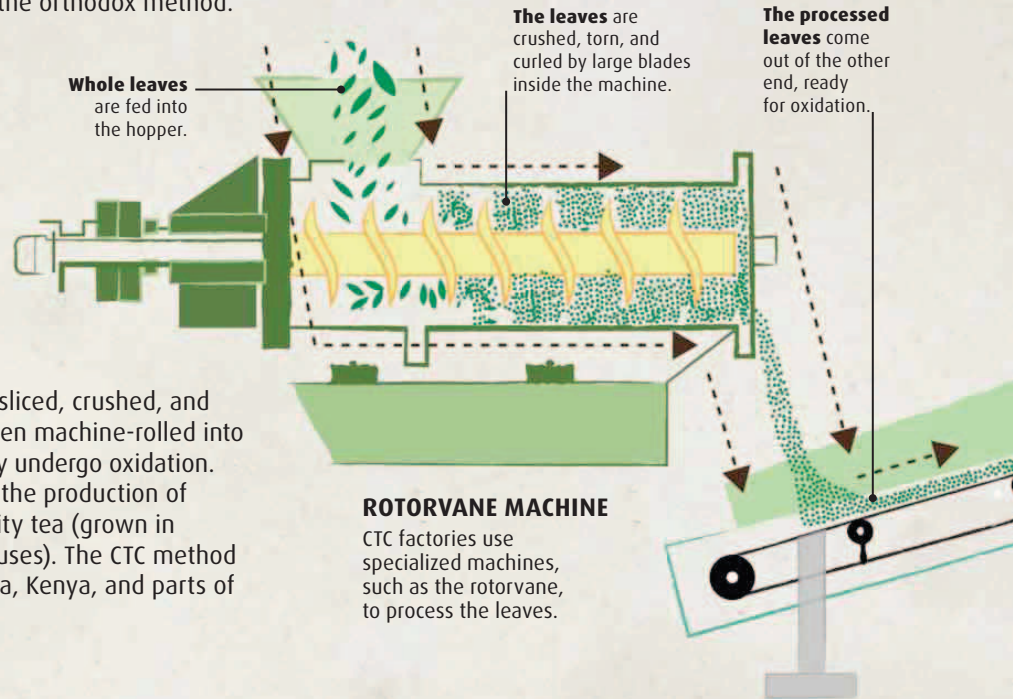
ORTHODOX METHOD

Orthodox-style tea is wholly or partially handmade, and aims to preserve as much of the whole leaf as possible. It is the standard method of production for all teas, except commercial black tea, which is usually produced using the CTC method. The whole leaf is regarded as superior in quality; leaves that break are ranked using the British grading system (see p90) in India, Sri Lanka, and Kenya, and priced accordingly. More tea producers are adopting this method due to the increasing demand for this type of tea.

There is an inverse relationship between quality and quantity, and therefore price. Although the quantity produced may be lower, higher prices per gram make up the difference.

UNBROKEN LEAF

Whole, unbroken leaves are the aim of orthodox tea production. Dry leaves are fragile and may break during the last stages.



GRANULAR TEA

CTC tea is almost always destined for the tea bag because it's broken into very small dustlike pieces, known as fannings, that release their flavor very quickly.

